

4.1 PHP—The What, Why And Whodunit

PHP is a server-side scripting language, and is the open source alternative to Microsoft's Active Server Pages (ASP). The two terms *Server Side* and *Scripting Language* deserve mention first. A server side language resides on the Web server, and users sitting at their respective workstations can interact with the language through the CGI (Common Gateway Interface), or directly through the Web server. What actually happens in a server side language is the code is designed to run on the server; for example when PHP code is encountered in a page requested by a visitor, the server executes it and the result is sent to the client. The benefit is that no plugin is required at the user's end, because nothing is downloaded to the browser. Servers-side languages are more powerful because, very simply put, they run on servers, and are not dependent on the capabilities of an unknown workstation present anywhere on the Net.

A Scripting Language is unlike other programming languages because it is interpreter-based, as opposed to compiler-based. Being an Interpreter-based language, it's easier to modify because individual lines of code can be executed, as opposed to compiler-based languages, where a complete sequence needs to be written.

PHP is gaining popularity every passing moment, and why not? The OSS (Open Source Software) tag means the entire code in which it was developed is openly available for whatever modifications users deem necessary. PHP is cross-platform, meaning it can be run on any Web server, and along with MySQL (a small database server) can be, for example, used to develop under Windows, and serve on a Linux platform or vice versa. OS independence is another strong feature—unlike ASP, which requires the Windows platform. Besides this, PHP is free!

PHP sees most frequent use with Apache (the Web Server) on most platforms. On the Windows side, PHP can be used with Microsoft's IIS (Internet Information Services). To get using PHP properly, you'll need a basic knowledge of HTML and XHTML.